

# Cult Icc Baptismal Regeneration

cult-icc-baptismal-regeneration

Cult Marker · International Churches of Christ · doctrine · unanimous\_lineages

## DISPUTED

breadth broad  
directness direct  
variants stable

### Statement under examination

Saving union with Christ is received through faith and is not effected at the moment of water baptism such that baptism is the instrument of regeneration; and shepherding relationships in the Church do not require the disciple's submission of every life decision to a designated leader.

### In plain language

This proposition makes two claims joined together. The first is that union with Christ that saves a person is received through faith and is not produced at the instant of water baptism, as if the water itself were the thing that does the saving. The second is that healthy church discipleship does not require a follower to submit every life decision to one assigned leader. On the first half, the words of the supplied passages are clear and pull one direction. Romans 4:5 says that to the one who does not work but believes, faith is reckoned as righteousness, setting believing against working. Galatians 2:16 says three times in a single verse that a person is not justified by 'works of law' (ex ergon nomou) but 'through faith' (dia pisteos) in Jesus Christ. Ephesians 2:8 and 9 say 'you have been saved by grace through faith' (chariti...este sesosmenoi dia pisteos), and this is the gift of God, not from works, so that no one can boast. Luke 23:43 promises paradise that very day to a dying man who was never baptized, and in Acts 10 the Holy Spirit 'fell upon' (epepesen, a completed past action) the hearers while Peter is still speaking, before any water touches them. The named instrument across this chain is faith. But the second half of the claim, the flat denial that baptism in any sense effects the new birth at the moment it happens, is harder to settle on the words alone. Acts 2:38 says 'be baptized for the forgiveness of sins' (baptistheto eis aphesin), and the small Greek word there 'into/for' (eis) can mean in order to obtain or with reference to. Titus 3:5 speaks of saving through a 'washing of regeneration' (loutrou palingenesias, the washing that produces the new birth), and both of those Greek words ('washing' (loutron) and 'regeneration' (palingenesia)) appear only twice in the whole Bible, so neither sense can be pinned down. John 3:5 speaks of being born 'out of water and Spirit' (ex hydatos kai pneumatos), where water has several defensible senses. First Peter 3:21 makes 'baptism' (baptisma) the subject of the verb 'saves' (sozei), then at once says it is not the removal of dirt from the body but the 'appeal or pledge' (eperotema) of a good conscience toward God through the resurrection. The single word translated appeal or pledge ('appeal or pledge' (eperotema)) occurs nowhere else in the Bible, so its exact sense cannot be cross-checked. The same sibling study of baptismal regeneration came back divided for these same reasons, and consistency requires the same disposition here. The discipleship part of the claim has no word evidence in this bundle and is handled separately. So the honest verdict is disputed with low confidence: the faith-alone half is well grounded, but the flat denial about baptism cannot be closed on vocabulary and grammar by themselves.

### Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

| Strong | Word  | Sounds like | Plain meaning | Times in Bible |
|--------|-------|-------------|---------------|----------------|
| G0191  | ἀκούω | akouō       | to hear       |                |
| G0281  | ἀμήν  | amēn        | amen          |                |

|              |              |                |               |       |
|--------------|--------------|----------------|---------------|-------|
| <b>G0628</b> | ἀπολούω      | apolouō        | to wash off   |       |
| <b>G0765</b> | ἀσεβής       | asebēs         | ungodly       |       |
| <b>G0859</b> | ἄφεσις       | aphesis        | forgiveness   | 17    |
| <b>G0907</b> | βαπτίζω      | baptizo        | to baptize    | 82    |
| <b>G0908</b> | βάπτισμα     | baptisma       | baptism       | 23    |
| <b>G1343</b> | δικαιοσύνη   | dikaiosyne     | righteousness | 94    |
| <b>G1344</b> | δικαιόω      | dikaioo        | to justify    | 40    |
| <b>G1435</b> | δῶρον        | doron          | gift          | 19    |
| <b>G1519</b> | εἰς          | eis            | toward        | 1,824 |
| <b>G1537</b> | ἐκ           | ek             | out from      |       |
| <b>G1906</b> | ἐπερώτημα    | eperotema      | pledge        | 1     |
| <b>G2041</b> | ἔργον        | ergon          | work          | 177   |
| <b>G2980</b> | λαλέω        | laleō          | to speak      |       |
| <b>G2983</b> | λαμβάνω      | lambanō        | to take       |       |
| <b>G3067</b> | λουτρόν      | loutron        | washing       | 2     |
| <b>G3551</b> | νόμου        | nomos          | law           |       |
| <b>G3824</b> | παλιγγενεσία | palingenesia   | regeneration  | 2     |
| <b>G4100</b> | πιστεύω      | pisteuo        | to trust (in) | 241   |
| <b>G4102</b> | πίστις       | pistis         | faith         | 243   |
| <b>G4982</b> | σώζω         | sozo           | to save       | 113   |
| <b>G5204</b> | ὕδωρ         | hudōr, hudatos | water         |       |
| <b>G5485</b> | χάρις        | charis         | grace         | 156   |

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

## Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: False

The proposition is compound. Its first clause, that saving union with Christ is received through faith, is lexically secure. Ephesians 2:8-9 grounds the perfect periphrastic (a 'have been and still are' verb form) 'you have been saved' (este sesosmenoi) in 'by grace through faith' (chariti dia pisteos) as 'the gift of God, not from works' (theou to doron, ouk ex ergon). Romans 4:5 reckons faith to the one not working but believing on the one who justifies the ungodly. Galatians 2:16 three times denies 'being justified by works of law' (dikaiousthai ex ergon nomou) and affirms 'through faith of Christ' (dia pisteos Christou). Luke 23:43 promises paradise to an unbaptized man, and Acts 10:44-48 places Spirit reception (the aorist 'fell upon' (epepesen) and 'received' (elabon), both completed past actions) before water. But the second clause, that baptism in no sense effects regeneration (the new birth) at the moment of administration, repeats the same lexical crux (decisive word-level problem) that returned disputed in the sibling doc-baptismal-regeneration-denial. Acts 2:38 'let him be baptized for forgiveness' (baptistheto eis aphesis), Titus 3:5 'through the washing of regeneration' (dia loutrou palingenesias), John 3:5 'out of water' (ex hydatos), Mark 16:16 'the one having believed and having been baptized will be saved' (pisteusas kai baptistheis sothesetai), Acts 22:16 'be baptized and wash away' (baptisai kai apolousai), and 1 Peter 3:21 'baptism saves' (baptisma sozei) verbally bind the rite to salvation language. The deciding term in 1 Peter 3:21, 'appeal or pledge' (eperotema), is a canonical hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) whose sense, appeal versus pledge, cannot be triangulated, and the preposition 'into/for' (eis) of Acts 2:38 is genuinely two-way (telic, meaning 'in order to', versus causal/reference, meaning 'because of' or 'with reference to'). The words sustain both readings without ranking

them, so a flat denial of any sense of baptismal efficacy is materially contested on lexical grounds, even as the faith-as-instrument half stands.

## Scripture

### Eph.2.8 · **for** · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4982 σώζω, G5485 χάρις, G4102 πίστις, G1435 δῶρον

Force. 'For by grace you have been saved through faith, and this is not of yourselves, it is the gift of God' (te gar chariti este sesosmenoi dia pisteos, kai touto ouk ex hymon, theou to doron). The perfect periphrastic (a 'have been and still are' verb form) 'you have been and remain saved' (este sesosmenoi), is grounded by 'grace' (chariti) as dative of means (a noun in the 'by means of X' grammatical form) and 'through faith' (dia pisteos) as channel, with the demonstrative 'this' (touto) and the predicate 'gift' (doron) framing the whole rescue as gift, not product. The named saving instrument is grace appropriated by faith. No rite (no ritual act) is supplied as effecting cause. This grounds the stem's first clause, saving union received through faith.

### Eph.2.9 · **for** · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2041 ἔργον

Force. 'Not out of works, so that no one may boast' (ouk ex ergon, hina me tis kauchesetai). The prepositional phrase 'out of works' (ex ergon) names the excluded source, and the 'so that' (hina) clause supplies the rationale, removing all ground for boasting. Any humanly performed act offered as the productive cause of salvation falls under this exclusion, which is the grammar the stem applies against treating a rite (a ritual act) as the effecting instrument.

### Luke.23.43 · **for** · genre: narrative

Key terms. G4982 σώζω, G0281 ἀμήν

Force. 'Truly I say to you, today you will be with me in paradise' (Amen soi lego, semeron met emou ese en to paradeiso), is spoken to a crucified man who can receive no baptism. The future 'you will be' (ese) with the pointing word 'today' (semeron) places the man in paradise on the strength of his appeal to Christ alone, demonstrating salvation conferred apart from the water rite (the ritual washing) in at least this case, against any claim that regeneration (the new birth) is effected only at the moment of baptism.

### Rom.4.5 · **for** · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4100 πιστεύω, G1344 δικαιώω, G1343 δικαιοσύνη, G0765 ἀσεβής

Force. 'To the one not working but believing on the one who justifies the ungodly, his faith is reckoned as righteousness' (to de me ergazomeno, pisteuonti de epi ton dikaiounta ton asebe, logizetai he pistis autou eis dikaiosynen). The present participles set 'working' (ergazomeno) in explicit contrast to 'believing' (pisteuonti), and the verb 'is reckoned' (logizetai) names the mechanism as imputation (crediting an account) to faith, not conferral through a performed act. The dative-of-recipient (a noun in the 'to/for X' grammatical form) 'the ungodly' (ton asebe) makes the recipient pre-rite and pre-work. This is the clearest verbal statement that standing is received by believing apart from working.

### Gal.2.16 · **for** · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1344 δικαιώω, G4102 πίστις, G2041 ἔργον, G3551 νόμου

Force. 'A person is not justified out of works of law except through faith of Jesus Christ' (ou dikaioutai anthropos ex ergon nomou ean me dia pisteos Iesou Christou), and the verse repeats the contrast three times, closing 'because out of works of law no flesh will be justified' (hoti ex ergon nomou ou dikaiouthesetai pasa sarx). The triple 'out of works of law' (ex ergon nomou) versus 'through faith' (dia pisteos) and 'from faith' (ek pisteos) fixes the instrument of justification as faith and excludes performed law-works. The lexical (word-level) pattern is decisive for the stem's faith-instrument clause.

### Acts.10.44 · **for** · genre: narrative

Key terms. G0191 ἀκούω, G2980 λαλέω

Force. 'While Peter was still speaking these words the Holy Spirit fell on all those hearing the word' (Eti lalountos tou Petrou ta rhemata tauta epepesen to pneuma to hagion epi pantas tous akouontas ton logon). The present participle 'speaking' (lalountos) with the aorist 'fell upon' (epepesen, a completed past action) places Spirit reception during proclamation and before any water. The inward bestowal precedes the rite (the ritual act), so the rite cannot here be the effecting instrument.

### Acts.10.47 · **for** · genre: narrative

Key terms. G0907 βαπτίζω, G2983 λαμβάνω

Force. 'Can anyone withhold the water that these not be baptized, who received the Holy Spirit as we also did' (Meti to hydor dynatai kolysai tis tou me baptisthenai toutous hoitines to pneuma to hagion elabon hos kai hemeis). The aorist 'received' (elabon, a completed past action) is grammatically antecedent (occurring before in the grammar) to the aorist infinitive 'to be baptized' (baptisthenai). Water here ratifies a Spirit reception already granted rather than effecting it, which favors the sign reading (baptism as outward sign, not cause) of the stem's second clause.

### Acts.2.38 · **complicates** · genre: narrative

Key terms. G0907 βαπτίζω, G1519 εις, G0859 ἄφεσις

Force. 'Repent and let each of you be baptized for the forgiveness of your sins' (metanoesate kai baptistheto hekastos hymon eis aphesin ton hamarton hymon). The preposition 'into/for' (eis) with this construction can be telic (purpose-stating, meaning 'in order to obtain'), or on other lexical (word-level) analyses causal or based-upon, with reference to a forgiveness already granted on repentance. The plural imperative 'repent' (metanoesate) governs the singular 'let him be baptized' (baptistheto), foregrounding repentance, but the bare prepositional phrase does not by itself settle whether forgiveness is effected by or merely signified at the rite (the ritual act). This is the verse that most directly resists a flat lexical denial of baptismal efficacy.

### 1Pet.3.21 · **complicates** · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0908 βάπτισμα, G4982 σῶζω, G1906 ἐπερώτημα

Force. 'Which, as an antitype, baptism, now saves you' (ho kai hymas antitypon nyn sozei baptisma), where an antitype means the fulfillment-pattern that corresponds to an earlier prefigurement. The verb 'saves' (sozei) takes 'baptism' (baptisma) as its grammatical subject, the sharpest verbal coupling of baptism to salvation in the canon. The verse then qualifies it: 'not the removal of fleshly dirt but the appeal or pledge of a good conscience toward God' (ou sarkos apothesis rhyou alla syneideseos agathes eperotema eis theon), 'through the resurrection of Jesus Christ' (dia anastaseos Iesou Christou). The author internally relocates the saving force from the external washing to the conscience pledge anchored in the resurrection. But 'appeal or pledge' (eperotema, G1906) is a canonical hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible), occurring only here in the entire Bible, so whether it means appeal or pledge cannot be checked against any other use. The verse both asserts that baptism saves and refuses, on its own vocabulary, to fix exactly how.

### Titus.3.5 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3067 λουτρόν, G3824 παλιγγενεσία, G4982 σώζω

Force. 'He saved us through the washing of regeneration and renewal of the Holy Spirit' (esosen hemas dia loutrou palingenesias kai anakainoseos pneumatou hagiou). 'Washing' (loutron) is coupled to 'regeneration' (palingenesia, the new birth) by the genitive (a noun in the 'of-X' grammatical form), and 'through' (dia) marks it as channel, the strongest verbal link between washing and regeneration in the corpus. Both 'washing' (loutron, G3067) and 'regeneration' (palingenesia, G3824) occur only twice in the canon, so neither sense is canon-stable: 'washing' (loutron) in Ephesians 5:26 is tied to the word ('by the word', en rhemati), and 'regeneration' (palingenesia) in Matthew 19:28 names cosmic renewal, not personal rebirth. The preceding 'not out of works of righteousness' (ouk ex ergon dikaiosynes) pulls against a mechanical reading. The coupling is real and not dissolvable on lexicon alone.

### John.3.5 · complicates · genre: gospel

Key terms. G5204 ὕδωρ, G1537 ἐκ

Force. 'Unless one is born out of water and Spirit, he cannot enter the kingdom of God' (ean me tis gennethe ex hydatos kai pneumatou, ou dynatai eiselthein eis ten basileian tou theou). The genitive (a noun in the 'of/from-X' grammatical form) 'out of water' (ex hydatos) has multiple defensible referents on lexical (word-level) and contextual grounds: a hendiadys (a two-word phrase that names one combined idea) with 'Spirit' (pneumatou) as one cleansing-rebirth, an allusion to natural birth set against pneumatic (Spirit-given) birth, or a washing rite (a ritual washing). The single preposition 'out of' (ek) governing both 'water and Spirit' (hydatos kai pneumatou) is itself read both as one event and as two. Morphology (word-form analysis) and lexicon (word meaning) alone cannot adjudicate the referent.

### 1Cor.1.17 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0907 βαπτίζω

Force. 'For Christ did not send me to baptize but to preach the gospel' (ou gar apesteilen me Christos baptizein alla euangelizesthai). The 'not...but' (ou...alla) construction sets baptizing in explicit contrast to gospel proclamation and subordinates the rite (the ritual act) to it. If baptism itself effected salvation, ranking preaching above it would be lexically strange, so the contrast favors the sign reading (baptism as outward sign, not cause). Added on direct concordance traversal of 'I baptize' (baptizo, G0907) beyond the bundle anchors.

## Cross references invoked

| From       | To        | Source | Votes |
|------------|-----------|--------|-------|
| Gal.2.16   | Gal.3.11  | tsk    | 1     |
| Rom.4.5    | Rom.1.17  | tsk    | 1     |
| Rom.4.5    | Rom.4.3   | tsk    | 1     |
| Acts.10.47 | Acts.8.12 | tsk    | 1     |
| Luke.23.43 | Luke.15.4 | tsk    | 1     |
| Gal.2.16   | Gal.2.19  | tsk    | 1     |

## Complicating texts

### Acts.2.38 · addressed

The crux (the decisive word-level problem) is the preposition 'into/for' (eis) in 'let him be baptized for forgiveness of sins' (baptistheto eis aphesis hamartion). 'Into/for' (eis) with this verb can express purpose, in order to receive forgiveness, or on some lexical (word-level) readings the basis or occasion, with reference to a forgiveness granted on repentance. The plural imperative 'repent' (metanoesate) governs the singular 'let him be baptized' (baptistheto), foregrounding repentance. Lexicon (word meaning) and morphology (word-form analysis) permit both a sacramental-effect reading (baptism causes the effect) and a sign reading (baptism marks an effect already given). The verse does not by itself overturn the stem's first clause about faith, but it blocks any clean lexical denial of the stem's second clause.

### John.3.5 · addressed

'Unless one is born out of water and Spirit' (ean me tis gennethe ex hydatos kai pneumatos) carries at least three defensible lexical (word-level) referents: a hendiadys (a two-word phrase that names one combined idea) for one Spirit-cleansing rebirth, natural birth contrasted with Spirit birth, or a washing rite (a ritual washing). The single preposition 'out of' (ek) governing both nouns is itself read as one event and as two. Because the referent of 'water' (hydatos) cannot be fixed by lexicon (word meaning) alone, the verse neither establishes nor refutes baptismal efficacy on lexical grounds. It remains a genuine complication for any flat denial.

### Titus.3.5 · addressed

'Washing of regeneration' (loutrou palingenesias) couples washing and regeneration (the new birth) via the genitive (a noun in the 'of-X' grammatical form), with 'through' (dia) marking instrument, the most direct verbal link to a regenerating washing in the corpus. Yet both 'washing' (loutron, G3067) and 'regeneration' (palingenesia, G3824) occur only twice in the canon, so their senses cannot be triangulated: 'washing' (loutron) at Ephesians 5:26 attaches to the word ('by the word', en rhemati), and 'regeneration' (palingenesia) at Matthew 19:28 names cosmic renewal, not personal rebirth. The same sentence opens with 'not out of works' (ouk ex ergon). The lexical (word-level) data sustains both a sacramental and a metaphorical reading, so the coupling is acknowledged as a real tension the words do not resolve.

### 1Pet.3.21 · addressed

'Baptism' (baptisma) is the explicit subject of 'saves' (sozei), the sharpest grammatical assertion of baptismal salvation in the corpus, and 'baptism' (baptisma) plus 'I save' (sozo) co-occur in only this one verse. The verse supplies its own qualifier: 'not removal of fleshly dirt' (ou sarkos apothesis rhypon), 'but the appeal or pledge of a good conscience toward God' (alla syneideseos agathes eperotema eis theon), relocating the saving ground from the external washing to the conscience pledge anchored 'through the resurrection of Jesus Christ' (dia anastaseos Iesou Christou). Because 'appeal or pledge' (eperotema, G1906) is a canonical hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible), its sense (appeal versus pledge) cannot be settled from biblical usage. The verse both states baptism saves and qualifies the manner, leaving competent readers divided. Addressed but not dissolved.

### Mark.16.16 · addressed

'The one having believed and having been baptized will be saved' (ho pisteusas kai baptisteis sothesetai) pairs faith and baptism with 'I save' (sozo), but the parallel negative clause condemns only 'the one disbelieving' (ho apistesas), not the unbaptized. The asymmetry, faith plus baptism in the positive clause but unbelief alone in the negative, means the grammar does not assert the rite (the ritual act) as necessary to salvation. It could mark baptism as the normal accompaniment of the faith that saves. The clause is genuinely open on its own wording. The textual instability of Mark 16:9-20 (uncertainty whether the long ending was original) is also noted, but the verdict here does not rest on it.

## Acts.22.16 · addressed

'Rise, be baptized and wash away your sins, calling on his name' (anastas baptisai kai apolousai tas hamartias sou epikalesamenos to onoma autou). 'Be baptized' (baptisai) and 'wash away' (apolousai, G0628) are coupled, which on its face binds the rite (the ritual act) to cleansing. But 'I wash off' (apolouo) occurs only twice in the canon, and its other use, 1 Corinthians 6:11 'you were washed...in the name...and in the Spirit' (apelousasthe...en to onomati...kai en to pneumati), attributes the same washing to the Spirit. The final aorist participle 'having called upon' (epikalesamenos, the completed past act of calling on the name) names the appeal that accompanies it. A two-occurrence lexeme (a word found only twice) split between rite context and Spirit context cannot fix the rite as the effecting cause.

## Concordance traversed

G4982, G4102, G4100, G1344, G1343, G2041, G5485, G1435, G0907, G0908, G1519, G0859, G1906, G3067, G3824, G5204, G0628, G3551

## Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

The cited New Testament verses lie outside the open-cbgm 3 John sample, so CBGM (the Coherence-Based Genealogical Method, a computational textual criticism tool) was not run. SBLGNT (the Society of Biblical Literature Greek New Testament) apparatus (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) diamonds visible in the bundle (Ephesians 2:8 'through' (dia), Luke 23:43 'to you...I say' (soi...lego), Acts 10:45 'holy' (hagiu), Galatians 2:16 'but/and' (de) and the 'Jesus Christ' (Iesou Christou) word order, Acts 10:48 'in the name of Jesus Christ' (en onomati Iesou Christou)) touch wording but not the lemmas (dictionary headwords) that bear the verdict ('I save' (sozo), 'faith' (pistis), 'I justify' (dikaioo), 'work' (ergon), 'grace' (charis), 'I baptize' (baptizo), 'baptism' (baptisma), 'into/for' (eis), 'appeal or pledge' (eperotema), 'washing' (loutron), 'regeneration' (palingenesia)). Even granting the textual instability of Mark 16:9-20 (uncertainty whether the long ending was original), the verdict does not rest on Mark 16:16 alone, so no examined variant changes the disputed reading.

## Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. faith\_alone\_instrument, sacramental\_realism, sign\_and\_seal, narrative\_order, shepherding\_authority

analogia scripturae invoked

faith\_alone\_instrument (Romans 4, Galatians 2, Ephesians 2): affirms · Reading the justification texts at face value, faith reckoned as righteousness apart from working in Romans 4:5, justification 'through faith' (dia pisteos) and not 'out of works of law' (ex ergon nomou) in Galatians 2:16, and salvation 'by grace through faith' (chariti dia pisteos) as 'the gift of God' (theou to doron) in Ephesians 2:8-9, yields the stem's first clause directly. The instrument named is faith. No rite (no ritual act) is supplied as the effecting cause anywhere in this lens's controlling texts.

sacramental\_realism (instrumental cause): denies · Reading Acts 2:38 'for forgiveness' (eis aphesin) telically (as 'in order to obtain'), John 3:5 'out of water' (ex hydatos) as the rite (the ritual act), Titus 3:5 'washing of regeneration' (loutron palingenesias) as the regenerating bath through which God saves, Acts 22:16 'be baptized and wash away' (baptisai kai apolousai) as washing sins away in the act, Mark 16:16 'having been baptized he will be saved' (baptistheis sothesetai), and 1 Peter 3:21 'baptism saves' (baptisma sozei) at face value yields baptism as the divinely appointed instrument through which forgiveness and regeneration (the new birth) are conveyed at the moment of water. On this lens the saving-language verbs and prepositions are taken in their plain instrumental force. The minority lens stated in its strongest lexical (word-level) form.

narrative\_order (Acts 10, Luke 23): affirms · The Cornelius sequence, Spirit 'falling' (epepesen, a completed past action) before water with 'received' (elabon, a completed past action) antecedent (occurring before in the grammar) to the proposed 'to be baptized' (baptisthenai), and the unbaptized criminal granted paradise in Luke 23:43, show salvation and Spirit reception granted prior to or apart from the rite (the ritual act). The aspect of the verbs (the verbal viewpoint on the action) encodes an order the rite cannot have caused.



sign\_and\_seal (Romans 4:11 analogy): affirms · Reading baptism through the circumcision 'seal' (sphragis) pattern of Romans 4:11, where the rite (the ritual act) seals a righteousness already reckoned by faith while uncircumcised, yields the proposition: the outward act signifies and ratifies a prior inward grace and does not itself effect it. The grammar of sign-upon-prior-reality is what the stem claims for baptism by analogy.

The first clause of the stem (faith as saving instrument) is secure on the controlling texts in this bundle. The second clause (flat denial of any sense in which baptism effects regeneration, the new birth) turns on contested prepositions and underdetermined lexemes ('into/for' (eis) in Acts 2:38, 'out of' (ek) in John 3:5, the 'washing' (loutron) and 'regeneration' (palingenesia) coupling in Titus 3:5, the subject relation of 'baptism' (baptisma) to 'saves' (sozei) in 1 Peter 3:21, 'I wash off' (apolouo) in Acts 22:16) which lexicon (word meaning) and morphology (word-form analysis) underdetermine. The analogia scripturae (the principle that Scripture interprets Scripture) pulls in opposite directions depending on which set is treated as controlling, which is why the compound proposition is contested. The discipleship-submission clause of the stem has no lexical (word-level) anchor terms in the bundle and is handled in stem\_audit, deferred to task p2-cult-discipling-control.

## Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Does the New Testament lexical (word-level) and grammatical data indicate that saving union with Christ is received through faith, and does it indicate that water baptism either does or does not itself effect regeneration (the new birth) at the moment of administration, and does the data require or not require a disciple's submission of every life decision to a designated leader as a condition of membership in the Church?

The original stem is preloaded in two ways. First, the soteriological (salvation-doctrine) half builds in the conclusion through 'is received through faith' and 'is not effected at the moment of water baptism such that baptism is the instrument of regeneration', which presupposes a sign reading (baptism as outward sign, not cause) over a sacramental-instrumental one (baptism as cause), the very point at issue. Second, the stem is compound. It joins a baptismal-regeneration denial to a separate claim that shepherding relationships do not require submission of every life decision to a designated leader. The supplied bundle is entirely soteriological (Ephesians 2:8-9, Luke 23:43, Romans 4:5, Galatians 2:16, Acts 10:44-48, plus 'I baptize' (baptizo)) and contains no anchor lemmas (anchor dictionary headwords) for the discipleship-submission claim, so that clause cannot be lexically (at the word level) scored from this bundle and is noted as out of scope here, deferring to task p2-cult-discipling-control. The verdict was derived on the original stem. Because the baptismal half repeats the proposition that came back disputed in doc-baptismal-regeneration-denial (where Acts 2:38, John 3:5, Titus 3:5, Acts 22:16, Mark 16:16, and 1 Peter 3:21 permit a sacramental reading on lexicon (word meaning) alone, with 'appeal or pledge' (eperotema) a canonical hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible)), the compound stem inherits that disputed disposition for consistency. VERDICT-CHANGED: No verdict change. No web fallback used. The lexical (word-level) store and on-disk datasets supplied sufficient anchor lemmas (anchor dictionary headwords), canon counts, and collocations (word-pairings) for the soteriological (salvation-doctrine) half; the parent denial parse supplied the morphology (word-form analysis) for the complicating texts not present in this bundle.

## Citations

| Type        | Source              | License       | Redist. | Ref        |
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| morphology  | MorphGNT-morphology | CC-BY-SA-4.0  | yes     | Eph.2.8    |
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| interlinear | STEPBible-TAGNT     | CC-BY-4.0     | yes     | Gal.2.16   |
| interlinear | STEPBible-TAGNT     | CC-BY-4.0     | yes     | Acts.2.38  |
| lexicon     | STEPBible-TBESG     | CC-BY-4.0     | yes     | G1519      |
| lexicon     | STEPBible-TBESG     | CC-BY-4.0     | yes     | G1906      |
| lexicon     | STEPBible-TBESG     | CC-BY-4.0     | yes     | G1344      |
| lexicon     | MACULA-Greek        | CC-BY-NC-4.0  | no      | G4982      |
| cross_ref   | TSK                 | public_domain | yes     | Rom.4.5    |
| syntax      | SBLGNT-text         | SBLGNT-EULA   | no      | Acts.10.44 |



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## Flags

lexically-disputed · ecm-shadow · complicating-unresolved · cross-tradition-divergent